

CHAPTER 1

The ochre stone walls of Vidhana Soudha had witnessed many storms, but that summer of 2026 felt like a deadly fever.

The sun was sinking behind the domes, bleeding into a sky the colour of dried chilli. Sirens wailed somewhere beyond the barricades. On the steps, a mob of cameras pointed like rifles at the giant building, each red light blinking, hungry for collapse.

On every news channel, anchors shouted over one another.

“In just eight months, Karnataka has lost its third coalition government—”

“—MLAs missing, allegedly flown to resorts—”

“—governor sends report to Delhi—”

“—constitutional breakdown—”

In the last eight months, this was the third time that the coalition government had literally evaporated. Cabinets were sworn in like temporary staff, promises were made on rented stages, and each time, sometime past midnight, power quietly changed hands in hotel corridors instead of the Assembly floor.

This chaos in Bengaluru had given a strong weapon to the power centre in New Delhi.

From a distance, Vidhana Soudha looked like a monument to democracy. Up close, that evening, it looked more like a fortress after a siege—pocked with protest posters, ringed by police in blue and khaki, and surrounded by a city that had run out of patience.

On one prime-time studio screen, a grainy archive clip appeared: the President taking oath years ago, the solemn words drowned now by the anchor’s voice-over.

"In India, we talk about power as if it is a blessing," the anchor said, trying to sound philosophical. "But let's be honest—no one gives power. You take it. Today, Delhi has decided to take back Karnataka."

The line stuck like a nail in the air.

Within minutes, the Prime Minister appeared on every channel, framed against the national flag.

"The people of Karnataka deserve stability," he declared. "The union cabinet has approved 'One Nation, One Election' for the state. Until then, to restore order and confidence, the state will come under President's Rule."

The words were heavy, bureaucratic, almost gentle on paper. On the streets, they landed like tear gas.

By midnight, defying everyone's expectations, the central government announced the name of the man who would seize control of Karnataka's administration under presidential rule.

"We are getting breaking news," a young anchor said, earpiece pressed tight. "The Centre has appointed a Special Administrator—an outsider—to run Karnataka. Repeat, an outsider."

The name rolled off her tongue with uncertain pronunciation, as if even the teleprompter was surprised.

"Dr. Sampath Kumar... renowned oncologist from Jharkhand."

In studios across the country, producers yelled at researchers.

"Who is he?"

"Check medical journals!"

"Get a picture—any picture!"

The media scrambled to dig into the background of this “unknown” individual. Old convocation photos were dragged out, conference selfies stolen from social media. A man in a white coat, stethoscope hanging, eyes tired but steady. A doctor, not a politician. A man used to cutting tumours out of bodies, now being asked to operate on a state.

Some said it was genius—send a clean man into a dirty war. Others said it was cruelty—throw a doctor into a pit of wolves.

Thousands of miles away in Ranchi, in a quiet lane far from any capital, the man himself was staring at the television in disbelief.

The ceiling fan hummed above the dining table. A bowl of half-eaten dal cooled beside folded rotis. The children’s schoolbags lay in a careless pile near the sofa. On the screen, next to the Prime Minister’s solemn face, was a photo of Sampath Kumar, taken fifteen years earlier at a hospital award ceremony.

Sampath’s fingers tightened around the edge of his chair.

“This... this has to be a mistake,” he whispered.

He had spent the day consulting patients, dictating case notes, occasionally thinking about the future in the small, practical ways of a middle-class professional. They had retirement plans for the next five years—maybe a quieter clinic, maybe a house with a small garden on the outskirts of Ranchi. That evening was supposed to be like any other: a normal dinner at home, the news muttering in the background, the children arguing about homework.

Instead, his own face stared back at him from four different channels.

Inside the house, his wife Priyadarshi watched the same announcement from the kitchen doorway, a wet plate frozen in her hand.

On screen, the anchor repeated the headline, tasting the drama of it.

“An oncologist from Jharkhand, Dr. Sampath Kumar, will now take over Karnataka’s administration under President’s Rule. A bold move by the Centre...”

Sampath didn't hear the rest. Somewhere beyond the thin walls of the house, an engine's growl grew louder.

He muted the TV.

The silence was sudden, unnatural.

Then came the sound of tyres on gravel. Headlights spilled through the front window, slicing across the living-room walls. The children, who had been half-listening, half-scrolling on their phones, looked up.

Black SUVs, their windows darkened, had pulled up outside the modest two-storey house. Doors opened and shut in quick, practised rhythm. Heavy boots hit the ground.

Someone began banging on the front door.

"Who is that?" Priyadarshi asked, the plate slipping slightly in her soapy hands.

Sampath moved to the window and parted the curtain just enough to see. Men in plain clothes with official badges hung around their necks. A local police officer stood a step behind them, sweating under the yellow streetlight.

He turned to his wife, and in that moment, the routine of their lives snapped like a dry twig. For years, people had come to their door bent with illness, begging for more time. This knock was different. It carried the weight of a distant capital, of files signed in sealed rooms.

When he spoke, there was no plea in his voice, no confusion. There was only the crisp authority of a doctor facing a crisis.

"Priya," he said, each word measured, "look at the news. They have crossed all limits. They announced my name. But remember, we are not going to be a part of this race."

From outside, fists hammered the door again, more urgently.

"Doctor sahab, please open the door!" a voice shouted, thick with rehearsed respect. "We have come from Delhi... this is an order from the Prime Minister's Office!"

The children stared, eyes wide. One of them whispered, "Papa...?"

Ignoring the commotion outside, Sampath locked eyes with Priyadarshi. The years of shared life—small arguments, late-night tea, hospital corridors, funerals, school meetings—all of it tightened into that single look.

"Priya," he said, voice low but unyielding, "turn off your phone and take the kids inside the room. Under no circumstances should the door be opened. Tell them we have nothing to discuss. We are not sacrificial goats they can drag into politics whenever they want. Get inside. Now."

There was a time when he would have softened the words, added a pleading "please." Not tonight.

Outside, the officers raised their voices.

"Dr. Kumar, this is a national duty!"

"Sir, you can't refuse like this—"

"You have been chosen by the highest office in the country—"

Priyadarshi saw the firmness in her husband's eyes and felt something inside her fall into line. Without argument, she nodded, wiped her wet hands on her saree, and moved swiftly towards the children.

"Come," she said, her own voice surprisingly steady. "Inside. Phones off."

The kids obeyed, sensing the rare seriousness in both parents. As they slipped into the inner bedroom, the corridor lights went off, one by one, until only the living-room lamp remained, throwing long shadows.

The banging on the door grew louder, but within the house, a different kind of silence settled—a silence with the precision of military discipline, the stillness of an operating theatre before the first incision.

Sampath walked to the television and switched it off completely. The blue glow vanished, taking with it the shouting anchors and scrolling headlines, but not the reality they had announced.

In Bengaluru, Vidhana Soudha shone under floodlights, encircled by battalions of cameras and police. In Delhi, men studied maps and graphs and called it strategy. In Ranchi, one man stood in front of a locked door, refusing the power that others would have killed to seize.

On a channel he could no longer see, a commentator tried to sound wise.

“In politics, nobody gives power,” the man said. “You either surrender to it, or you take it.”

In the quiet house in Ranchi, Sampath Kumar made a third choice.

He chose to shut the door.

The officers outside kept knocking, their impatience echoing through the thin walls, through the modest rooms, through the retirement plans folded and kept in some forgotten diary.

The game of fate had only just begun.